Stigma in cultural context:
Educators' beliefs about disability in Japan and South Korea

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Overview of the research

Research Questions

- What are the roles of peers in the social and cultural construction of stigma in relation to children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities in Japan and South Korea?
- How do educators facilitate positive relationships between children with disabilities and their peers?

Characteristics of Children with Mild Cognitive and Behavioral Disabilities

- Their diagnoses include learning disabilities, ADHD, and high-functioning autism.
- They appear "normal and healthy" and in many areas, function well.
- Their behaviors/difficulties may be misinterpreted as laziness, disobedience, disrespect, etc.
- They may be at risk for delay in receipt of appropriate services and educational neglect.
- Increase in the number of children who are identified as having mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities [both in Japan and South Korea]

Conceptual Framework

- Co-construction of stigma and attitudes towards children with disabilities (Varenne & McDermott, 1998)
  - Peers play important roles in children's co-construction of positive/negative attitudes toward disability and in the support for children with disabilities in their classroom.

Methods

- Semi-structured, audio-recorded individual in-depth interviews with educators (including administrators).
- Participants described their perceptions and experiences working with children with disabilities.
- All data were collected and analyzed in participants' native language.
- Using analytic induction techniques, the meanings of participants' perceptions and experiences were interpreted through repeated readings of transcribed interviews.
- Cross-cultural variations and similarities were examined through on-going discussion among researchers.

Characteristics of the Study Participants

Japan: 26 educators from 4 areas in Japan
[6 males & 20 females; Years of experience: 2 to 40]
South Korea: 43 educators in a metropolitan area
[2 males and 41 females; Years of experience: 6 to 40]



Socio-cultural, Historical & Policy context

Japan

- **Practice of *mimamori*** (watching over): Preference of implicit communications, e.g., "guiding" parents to understand their children's special needs, rather than explicitly suggesting available resources.
- **Importance of *Ibasho*** (sense of place and belonging): Children create their own *Ibasho*, either in general and special ed. classrooms.
- **"Other people's eyes"** [concerns about what other people think] can influence how people act.
- Took nearly 30 years to implement the new special ed.
  - **Concern about labeling** children who look "normal"
- Created **a new term, "developmental disabilities."**
  - Differentiate from other disabilities
  - Less stigma than other disabilities

Policy responses

New special education involving support for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities started **in 2007.**

- **Incremental implementation** of the new system
  - Spent 30 years to research and prepare
- **No significant consequences** for not implementing policies
  - Allows creativity, but the level of implementation may vary in each school/city.
- **Educators' flexible roles**
  - Support may be provided by teachers who do not hold special ed. certificate.

South Korea

- Influence of Confucianism: The main purpose of special education is **"The unification of the society"**
- **Confucian values**: Controlling emotions, obedience to authority, conformity and saving face
- A culture of **homogeneity**: "Disability" can make people different from others, which can expose them to the risk of stigmatization
- Children's problems: Responsibility of mothers and teachers
- **Parents' reluctance** to involve a third party, including educators
- Mothers make **negative self-attributions** based on their children's disabilities
- More concern about **academic achievement**

Policy responses

Expansion of special education categories **in 2008**, including autism and developmental delay (**but not ADHD**)

- **Legal enforcement** for implementing the new system
  - Strict enforcement and penalty
  - Pressure for general education classroom teachers
- **Clear roles determined by the laws**
  - General ed. classroom teacher: Classroom-based interventions
  - Special education teachers: Support at resource rooms

Results

The Importance of Peers as Reflected in Policies

Japan

Education has to be provided in order to promote full character/personality development and raise children who are healthy both physically and mentally and who have abilities to contribute to the formation of a peaceful and democratic nation and society. (Fundamental Law of Education, Article 1, Paragraph 1)

- Holistic education
  - 3 components of elementary education: Academic skills, moral education, and health and physical education
  - "Moral education has to be done in a way that facilitates children's relationships with peers and teachers in collaboration with families and the community through various activities." (Ministry of Education, 2008)
- Education for *Kokoro* (heart & mind)
  - Personality education
  - Occur in all activities at school, not only in academic instruction.



South Korea

The purpose of education is to enable every citizen to lead a life worthy of human and to contribute to the development of a democratic country and realization of an ideal of human co-prosperity by ensuring cultivation of character, development of abilities for independent life and necessary qualities as a democratic citizen under the humanitarian ideal.
(Framework Act on Education, Article 2)

- Education of "the whole person"
  - Development of creativity and the cultivation of human nature of students
- "Benefit for all mankind"
  - Empowerment through peer relationships
  - Lead to inclusive education
- Confucianism
  - Help children with disabilities to develop into Korean adults contributing to a unified society.

Peers' roles in the life of children with disabilities at school

Influence of peers' reactions to children with disabilities on the degree of stigma

"I'm not sure, but I feel that they don't care much [about going to the resource room]. …You may worry… if other children may look them weird, or they don't feel good about [other children's reactions]… [Fortunately] children who are currently going to [the resource room] do not have such problems."

"Some children feel ashamed to come [to special education classrooms]. They are struggling with other children's eyes and reactions. Despite their low cognitive ability, they don't like [to go to special education classrooms] because they are able to notice other children's reactions [to them]. So, there are some cases that those children themselves decided full inclusion."

Create a "kind" classroom atmosphere

"If there is a child with a disability, other children grow…not in a bad way… There are children who look them as "special" but [we try] to make it in a way that has positive impacts, and raises other children's *kokoro* [heart and mind]"

"For parents, elementary schools are supposed to be a place [their child] is with others, has many friends and do together with friends. Well, [if they have to do it] alone, they can do at home. It looks like that. As far as they are at school, they are not alone."

"[It seems like] they are taking care of babies. Students in my classroom, especially girls seem to take care of babies like their mothers [did to them]. When the child [with disability] is acting out, the girls take the child back to his chair. In this way… So, [they] really enjoy help [the child] well."

"My classroom is getting kind because of the child [with disability]. All children try to help the child as well as each other."

Teachers' interactions with peers of children with disabilities

Help children understand their peers with disabilities and include them

"Well, if a classroom teacher indicates and tries to correct what that child is not good at, other children begin to see that this child is not good at that, so, …I praised, as much as possible, what is good at with that child, … I tried to accommodate so that other children can notice…or feel that they are not definitely a 'bad child'… but they also have something very good. …How other children look at that child is very important."

"I talk with other children to do better for the child. Because, they are able to understand to some extent. I tell them, 'We shouldn't have preconceived notion that the child will always behave like that. We might also become like them if we get involved in some sort of an accident. So, we can put ourselves in their shoes and understand their difficulties. We can help our friends.'"

"I use compliments and rewards to encourage other children to help them because those are very effective."

Teacher's use of metaphor to help peers understand struggles of children with disabilities

Nagai *sensei* discussed the need to "raise" all children to recognize, understand and empathize with the struggles of others …

"I explained to them [Naoto's classmates] that everyone has a different amount that they are able to bear/tolerate (*gaman*). Everyone has a cup [of tolerance], but it's different one by one. Someone has a large cup, but there is someone who has a small cup. We can't change the size of our cups easily. So, there is a person who wants to *gaman* but can't… When [Naoto] became upset, other children said, 'His cup has overflowed.'" (Kayama & Haight, 2014, p. 1)



"Amongst us are some children that are initially born with small thinking pockets. It is neither the child's fault nor the parents' fault. They are just friends that are born with small thinking pockets. But, kids with severer disabilities are those with small heart-pockets. That is how I explain about disabilities to children. Understanding those disabilities is more difficult than physical disabilities."



Discussion: Cultural nuances

Discussion

- In both Japan and Korea, educators have experienced the recent transition of special education systems involving support for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities.
- Findings of this study suggest both cultural variation and similarities across cultures.
- In both counties, typically developing peers played important roles in the support for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities. Yet their beliefs, experiences and practices are culturally nuanced.

Japan

- Less stigma for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities than for those with other types of disabilities
- Classroom teachers prefer to provide extra support for children with disabilities as "naturally" as possible.
- Educators may involve typically developing peers in the support for children with disabilities.
- Flexibility in the support for children with disabilities is emphasized: Utilize problems children are facing as an opportunity for them to learn
- Educators described how they provide support so it does not look "special" to typically developing peers.

South Korea

- Sensitivity to stigma is stronger, e.g., ADHD is not considered "disability."
- Educators focus on developing disability awareness programs to promote positive perspectives on children with disabilities.
- Educators encourage children to understand the struggles of their peers with disabilities more explicitly.
- South Korea has developed a more structured special education system (e.g., clear roles for general and special education teachers.)
- Educators described peers' sensitivity to teachers' responses to children with disabilities rather than the "differences" caused by their disabilities.

Implications for U.S. Educators

These cultural cases will provide U.S. educators with new perspectives from which to reflect on their own practices and develop new intervention programs for children from culturally diverse communities.

What can you learn from Japan and South Korea?